



MAKOLA.IO – BUSINESS BRIEFING

Makola in Pictures

Everything that has been built,
everything that blocks a single cedi of
revenue, and the three one-hour
decisions that change the shape of the
business.

31 August 2026

Prepared against the repository

Companion

Makola Reconciliation (full
written report)

Nine pages

Charts first, prose second

Supersedes

docs/business-plan/, June-July
2026

Five months of building. Nothing sold.

A platform of unusual completeness, delivered fast and to a high standard, with no revenue mechanism switched on.

■ Built and working
 ■ Open or unknown
 ■ Blocked or losing money

These three colours mean the same three things on every page.

185,556

Lines of application code

7,174

Automated tests, all passing in CI

5

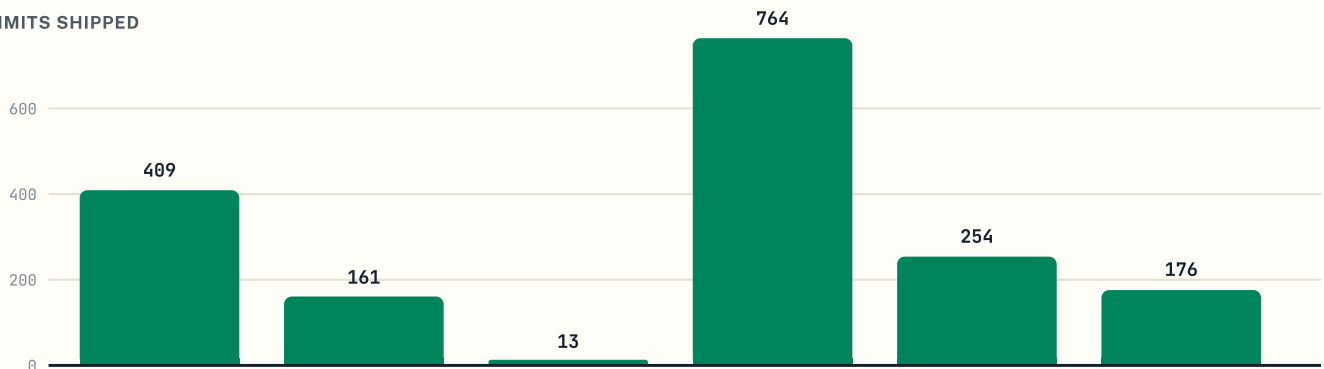
Merchants who signed up on their own

GHS 0

Platform revenue, all time

WORK DELIVERED, MONTH BY MONTH — AGAINST MONEY EARNED

COMMITTS SHIPPED



PLATFORM REVENUE (GHS)

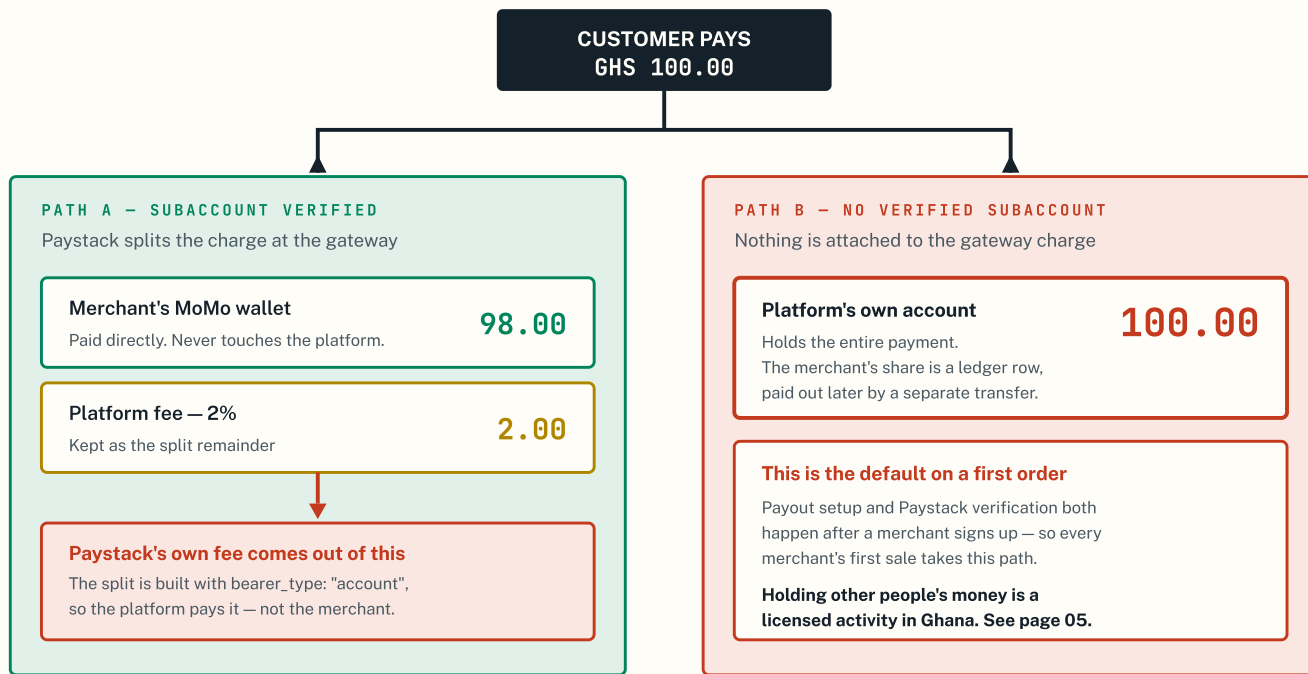


Both panels share one timeline. June's 764 commits are the month the revenue rails were finished — the fee, the split, the payout engine. Everything since has been more product. The revenue line has never left zero. [REPO](#) Commit counts from git history; revenue from project records.

This was diagnosed inside the project on 20 June: “Risk has been retired on the supply side (code) where it was comfortable, not on the demand side where it is highest.” The same document set an avoid list — no new features, no mobile app, no marketplace — and opened a 90-day window that closes on **18 September 2026**. July and August delivered a brand refresh, a design studio, directory scoring and chat attachments. All good work. None of it demand-side.

Follow one customer's GHS 100

A shopper pays. What happens next depends on one thing most people would not guess: whether that merchant has finished payout setup and been verified by Paystack.



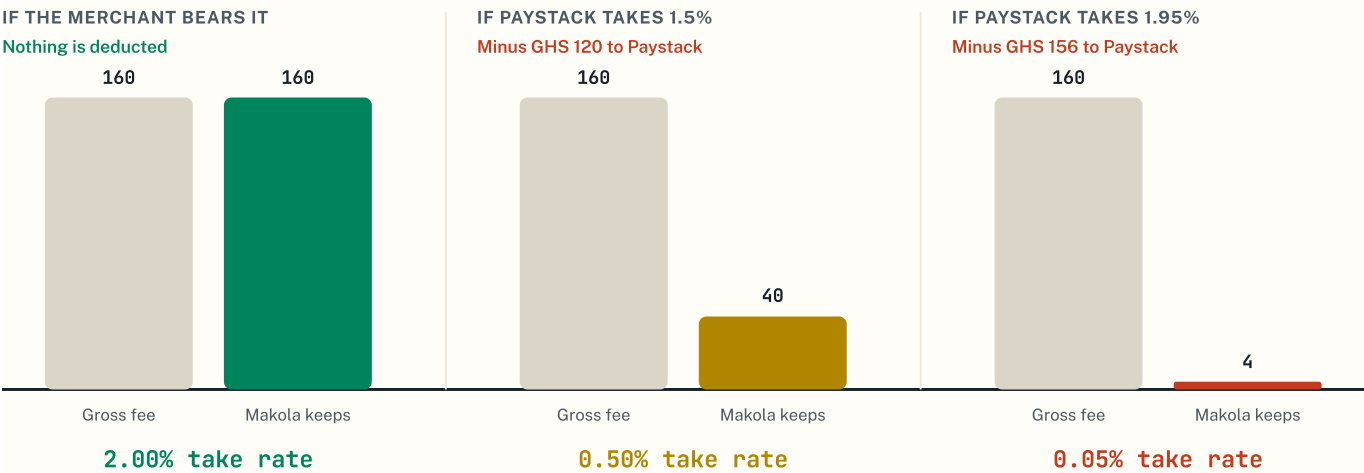
Both paths are live in the code today. `REPO order_settlement.ex` routes any merchant without a verified subaccount to the internal-hold path, tagging every allocation `settlement_method: :internal_hold`. The GHS 100 figure is illustrative; the 2% rate and the routing logic are read from source.

Why this matters more than it looks. The company has been treating fund custody as a future design decision, correctly gated on legal advice. But Path B is not a future decision — it is what happens today, on the very first transaction any new merchant processes. The exposure already exists.

Who pays Paystack decides whether there is a business

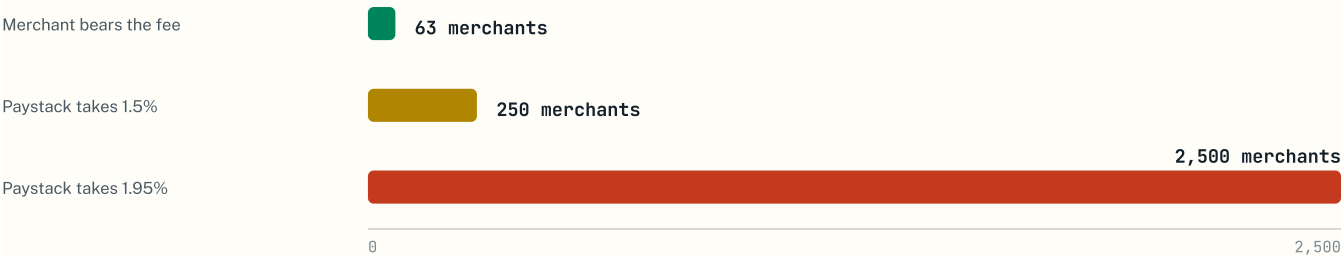
Makola takes 2% of a sale. Paystack takes a cut of the same sale. One configuration value decides which of them absorbs it — and right now it is Makola.

WHAT MAKOLA ACTUALLY KEEPS, PER MERCHANT, PER MONTH



The right-hand bar in each pair is the whole business, per merchant, per month. All three pairs start from the same GHS 160. **REPO** The 2% fee and `bearer_type: "account"` are read from source. **MODEL** Paystack's actual Ghana rate is unknown and must be confirmed; GHS 8,000 of monthly sales is an assumption, not a measurement.

MERCHANTS NEEDED TO EARN GHS 10,000 A MONTH



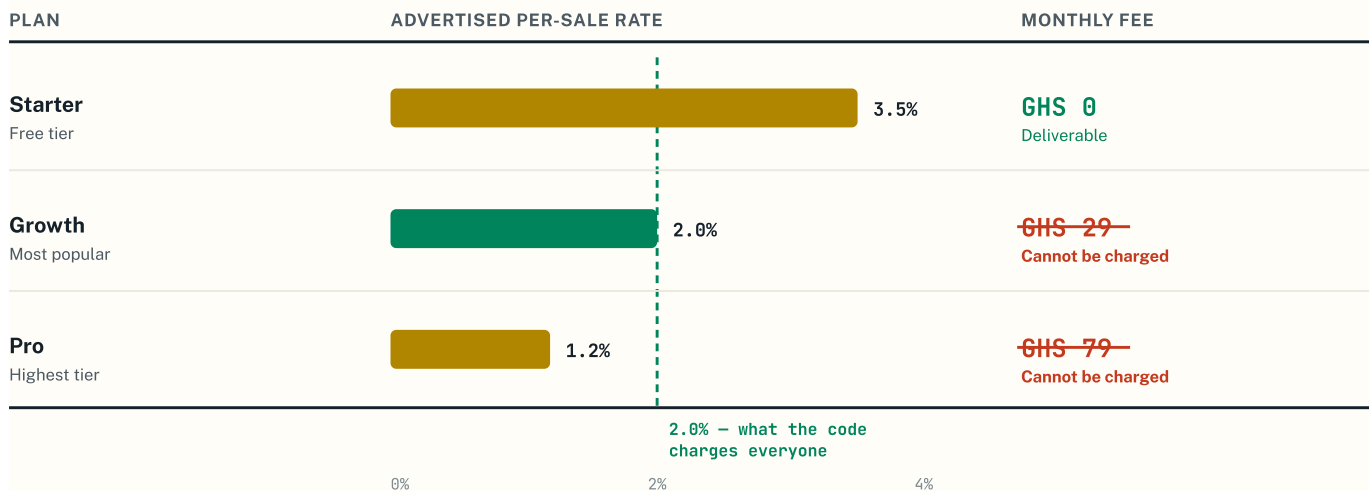
Bars are to scale. The difference between the top bar and the bottom bar is one configuration line. **MODEL** GHS 10,000 per month is a reference point for legibility, not a target.

The action. Confirm Paystack Ghana's mobile-money rate, then set the fee bearer deliberately. A merchant-borne gateway fee is the ordinary arrangement in this market — it is what a customer already pays when sending money to a MoMo number — so it is unlikely to be the objection the current default assumes. Cost: one email and one configuration line. **REPO** `docs/ACTION_ROADMAP.md` still lists “Paystack fee bearer” as an open decision. The code already made it.

Three plans are advertised. One can be delivered.

The live pricing page sells two monthly subscriptions and three different per-sale rates. The system can charge none of the subscriptions and only one of the rates.

WHAT THE PAGE PROMISES, AGAINST WHAT THE CODE DOES



Only one bar touches the green line. Every merchant is charged a flat 2%, so Starter customers are under-charged against the page and Pro customers over-charged. **REPO** Rates from `pricing_live.ex`; the flat fee from `platform_fee_rate_bps: 200`.

WHY THE SUBSCRIPTIONS CANNOT BE BILLED

The billing code is for Stripe, which does not operate in Ghana

UNUSABLE

The Subscription resource is keyed on `stripe_subscription_id` and `stripe_customer_id`. Plan requires `stripe_product_id` and `stripe_price_id`.

It was never connected to a store

NOT WIRED

A subscription belongs to an Organisation, not a Store. It also counts `max_agents` and `max_api_calls_per_month` — leftovers from the SaaS template this project was scaffolded from.

The local-gateway handler was never written

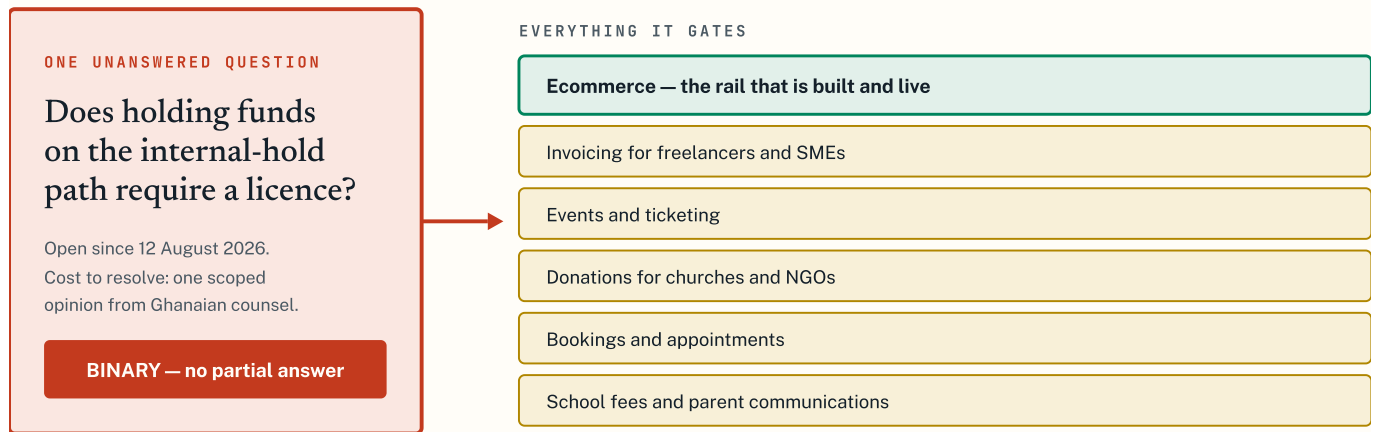
STUB

The one worker that would process a Paystack billing event contains a single comment: `TOD0`: Implement Paystack and Hubtel webhook handling in Phase 1.5.

The one-hour fix. Reduce the live page to the single free tier at the rate actually charged. Restore the paid tiers only when a Paystack recurring charge exists. Building subscription billing instead is weeks of work with no evidence of demand behind it. **REPO** The project's own brand-kit rules already flag the mismatch: *"The advertised plan rates and what OrderSettlement charges do not agree yet."*

The question that decides everything else

Ghana's Payment Systems and Services Act, 2019 regulates holding other people's money. Whether Makola's settlement design falls inside that has never been put to a lawyer.



Every adjacent business reuses the same settlement and payout rail, so all five inherit the same answer. One legal opinion unlocks — or closes — all of them at once. [REPO](#) Verticals from docs/SAAS-PIVOT-OPPORTUNITIES.md.

WHY IT RANKS FIRST

It is binary. Either the design is lawful at current capital or it is not. There is nothing to manage in between.

It gets worse with volume. Held funds belonging to real merchants are a far worse position to discover a licensing problem from than an empty ledger.

It is cheap relative to its weight. One scoped opinion costs a fraction of a month's engineering.

THE PRECEDENT TO FOLLOW

The same team already handled an adjacent question well. Research into Ghana Card identity checks found that retaining card images was itself the violation, and that the duty to verify did not bind Makola at all. The card flow was removed and replaced with a wallet-proof one-time code. [RECORD](#)

That is the argument for doing the same here: get the specific question answered rather than designing around a guess. The project's notes carry a capital figure of GHS 800,000, unverified and cited only for order of magnitude — it should not be repeated as researched.

What is switched on, and who holds each switch

A great deal is built but off, waiting on a credential or a decision. Sorting by who can flip the switch separates a week of your own time from a dependency on someone else.

YOU HOLD THESE SWITCHES

Live Paystack keys

Without them every charge is a test charge. This is the single gate on all transaction revenue.

PLACEHOLDER

Fix the exposed identity document

A merchant's KYC file is readable by anyone with the link. Must be closed before onboarding anybody.

OPEN

Decide the Paystack fee bearer

See page 03. One email, one configuration line, and the largest single swing in the model.

UNDECIDED

Make the pricing page honest

Reduce to the single free tier at the rate actually charged. One hour.

OPEN

Run the founding-seller campaign

The playbook, the scripts and the funnel maths were written on 20 June and have not been used.

NOT STARTED

SMS sender ID and credits

Regulatory approval takes under a day. Currently a placeholder key.

PLACEHOLDER

Purge the demo and test stores

Tooling exists and is tested. Leaves a directory showing only real merchants.

PENDING

Custom domains · social login · subdomains

Fully built, deliberately switched off. Nothing revenue-critical. Leave them off.

DARK

SOMEONE ELSE HOLDS THESE

WhatsApp Business API — waiting on Meta

No WhatsApp message has ever been delivered in production. This is the headline benefit in every sales script, and it does not work. SMS is in the same state.

BLOCKED

Custody opinion — waiting on counsel

Long lead time, so instruct first. See page 05.

BLOCKED

Subaccount verification — Paystack, per merchant

Until each merchant is verified, their orders take the internal-hold path on page 02.

PER MERCHANT

REPO Gates from `LAUNCH_TODO.md` and `.env.example`. **RECORD** The current state of production credentials comes from project records and was not re-checked against the live server for this briefing — confirm before relying on it externally.

Ranked by damage, not by likelihood

A merchant's identity document is publicly readable

R1 · OPEN SINCE 28 AUG

A KYC file returns successfully to anyone with the link, unauthenticated. The application asks for private storage, but that does not make a file private on a bucket that is itself public. This is a personal-data breach involving a real person who trusted the platform, and the most damaging thing that could surface during a sales conversation or any due diligence. **Fix before onboarding anyone.**

Money is held in custody on the default path

R2 · OPEN SINCE 12 AUG

See pages 02 and 05. Not a future design decision — it is what happens on every merchant's first order today.

Prices are advertised that cannot be charged

R3 · OPEN

Two paid tiers with no billing mechanism, and none of the three advertised per-sale rates matches the flat 2% actually taken. A merchant selecting Growth today has been quoted a price that cannot be honoured. See page 04.

Messages fail silently

R4 · OPEN

Neither WhatsApp nor SMS has ever delivered in production. Separately, all production email was dead for roughly nineteen days on a deleted provider key — and the application reported success throughout, because a queued send returns a success value regardless of what the provider does with it. **After any credential change, verify at the provider's own records, never at the application's return value.**

One person is the entire company

R5 · STRUCTURAL

Every commit, deployment, credential and all domain knowledge sit with one part-time, remote person, and the deployment path depends on their own machine. Any interruption stops the business. It also caps demand-side work: the outreach campaign needs 30 to 45 minutes a day, competing directly with the engineering that has absorbed the available hours for five months.

One payment provider holds every rail

R6 · STRUCTURAL

Collection, splitting, subaccounts and payouts all run through Paystack. They set the rate that determines margin, gate each merchant's first payout, and compete in the same market through Paystack Commerce. The alternative gateway is built behind a clean interface but is not the live rail — a defensive investment worth making after revenue exists, not before.

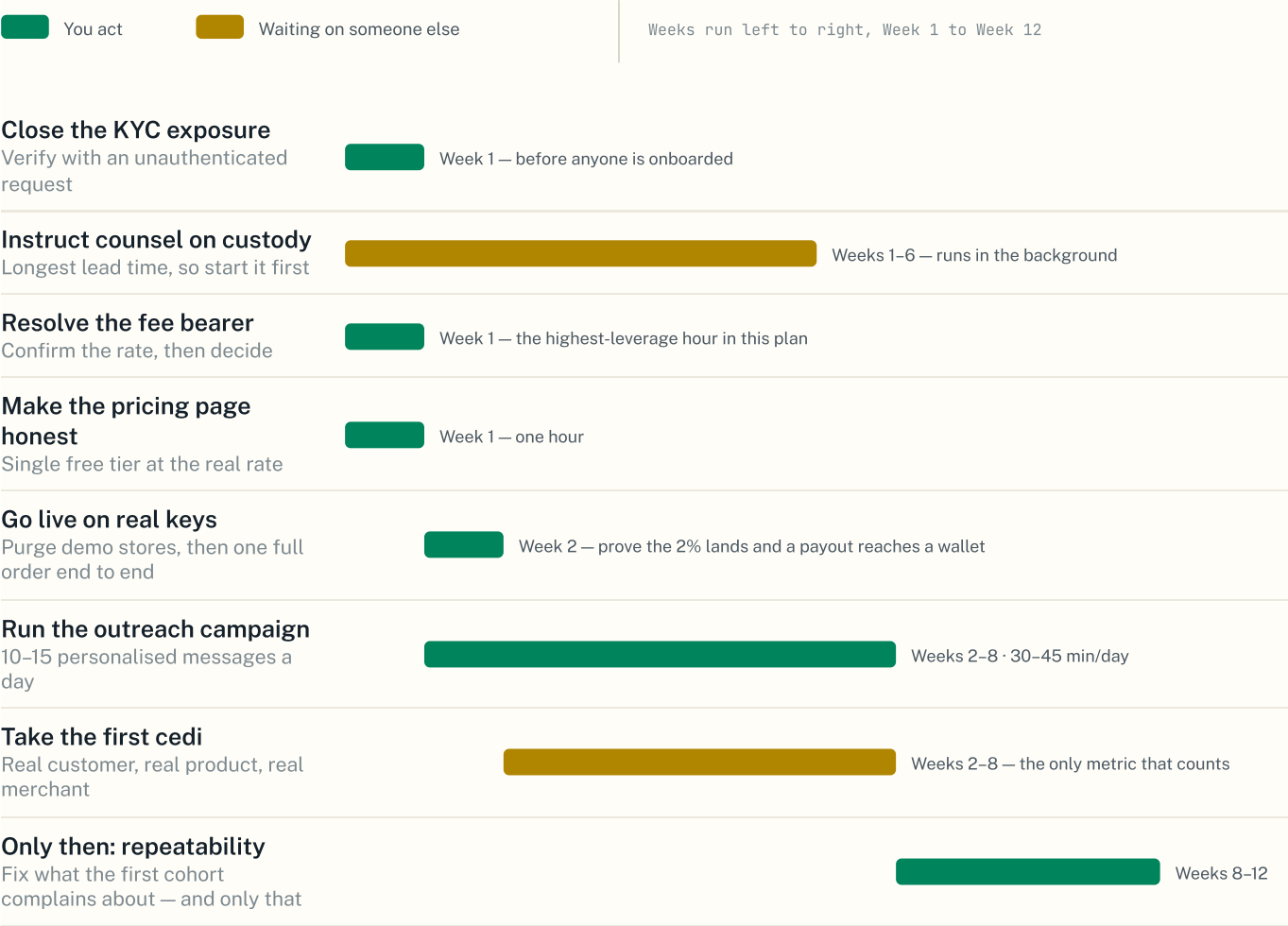
Infrastructure will not scale as configured

R7 · MANAGED

One small application machine against a database that will not survive additional machines. A real ceiling, but a distant one that binds at a merchant count the business does not have. Size the database before scaling the application. This is a good problem to reach.

Freeze product. Close three gates. Sell.

One recommendation, not a menu. Everything below is either a gate on taking money or a demand-side action. Nothing on it is a new feature.



EXPLICITLY NOT ON THIS LIST

Subscription billing. The mobile app. Nigeria. Custom domains. The supplier marketplace. Further theme, brand or design work. Any adjacent vertical. Each may be right later. None of them moves a cedi in the next ninety days — and the last five months are the evidence for how easily they absorb the hours that selling needs.

When to stop, and what would change the answer

The June plan wrote its own stopping rule. It is a good one, and it deserves a date attached.

CONDITION ONE

The product must be chargeable

Live keys, a working fee, a payout that reaches a wallet. Until then a seller cannot transact.

CONDITION TWO

The effort must have been made

150 personalised messages, sent. Not planned, not scripted — sent.

If both hold on 30 November 2026 and fewer than five sellers are taking real orders — the constraint is not code

Neither condition held in June, which is why the original 90-day test could not fire. Both are inside the plan on page 08.

GOOD NEWS WOULD LOOK LIKE

Counsel says custody is fine at current capital. The largest overhang lifts, the settlement redesign becomes buildable, and all five adjacent verticals open at once.

Paystack's rate is low, or the merchant bears it. The take rate becomes a real 2%, break-even sits at dozens of merchants rather than thousands, and the model works as designed.

Outreach converts above the projected rate. Demand risk retires, and the right response is to spend — cautiously — on reach.

BAD NEWS WOULD LOOK LIKE

Counsel says custody is a licensed activity. The design must change to a non-custodial structure, or the business needs capital it does not have. That would be the moment to ask whether the engine is worth more inside an existing licensed operator than standing alone.

The campaign runs in full and nobody transacts. The constraint is the segment or the offer. Change one of those, or move the engine to a vertical from page 05. Do not respond by writing more code.

IN CLOSING

The asset is real and rare: a tested, secure, multi-tenant mobile-money commerce and payouts engine, built to a standard most funded teams do not reach, by one person in five months. Nothing here is a criticism of the work.

What it lacks is the only thing code cannot supply. Three of the next ninety days' actions cost an hour each — a storage permission, a configuration line, and an email to a lawyer. The fourth costs forty minutes a day, and it is the one that has been deferred for five months. That is the whole plan.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS IN THIS DOCUMENT

REPO Read directly from the source code. Reproducible.

RECORD From project notes. Confirm before external use.

MODEL An assumption, not a measurement.

This briefing could not query the live server, so production merchant counts, transaction history and credential state come from project records. Paystack Ghana's commercial rates and the exact licence threshold under Act 987 are both outside the repository and must come from those parties directly. The full written analysis, with source file references for every claim, is the companion document **Makola Reconciliation**.